

Use of commas



THE LONDON SCHOOL
OF ECONOMICS AND
POLITICAL SCIENCE ■

Useful resource



A guide to punctuation by Larry Trask, Sussex University

<https://www.sussex.ac.uk/informatics/punctuation/toc>



4 main uses



1. The Listing Comma
2. The Joining Comma
3. The Gapping Comma
4. Bracketing Commas

The listing comma



The listing comma is used in lists of three or more.

- Hungarian is spoken in Hungary, western Rumania, northern Serbia and parts of Austria and Slovakia.
- You can fly to Bombay via Moscow, Athens or Cairo.
- Lisa speaks French, Italian and Spanish

The listing comma



Omitting the comma can change the meaning.

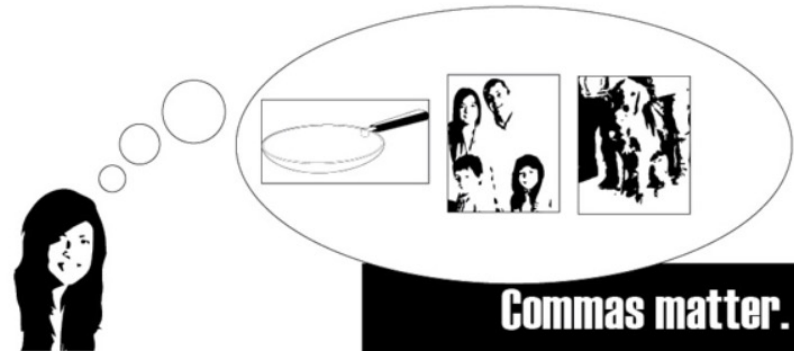
Compare:

- I find inspiration in cooking my family and my dog.
- I find inspiration in cooking, my family and my dog.

The listing comma

Omitting the comma can change the meaning. Compare:

- I find inspiration in cooking my family and my dog.
- I find inspiration in cooking, my family and my dog.



Commas matter.

The Oxford comma



In British English, it is not common to put a listing comma before the word *and* or *or* (sometimes known as the ‘Oxford comma’).

- Hungarian is spoken in Hungary, western Rumania, northern Serbia and parts of Austria, and Slovakia.
- You can fly to Bombay via Moscow, Athens, or Cairo.
- Lisa speaks French, Italian, and Spanish

The Oxford comma



Sometimes an Oxford comma is necessary to clarify meaning.

Compare:

- I dedicate this award to my parents, Jane Austen and Albert Einstein.
- I dedicate this award to my parents, Jane Austen, and Albert Einstein.

A well-known joke



A panda walks into a café. He orders a sandwich, eats it, then draws a gun and fires two shots in the air.

"Why?" asks the confused waiter, as the panda makes towards the exit. The panda produces a badly punctuated wildlife manual and tosses it over his shoulder.

"I'm a panda," he says at the door. "Look it up."

The waiter turns to the relevant entry in the manual and, sure enough, finds an explanation.

"Panda. Large black-and-white bear-like mammal, native to China. Eats, shoots, & leaves."

A well-known joke



The panda eats shoots and leaves.



A well-known joke



The panda eats, shoots, and leaves.



The listing comma



A listing comma is also used with when a series of two or more adjectives independently modify a noun and are roughly equal in importance (coordinate adjectives).

This is a provocative, disturbing book.

The sweet, scintillating aroma of cinnamon buns filled the kitchen.

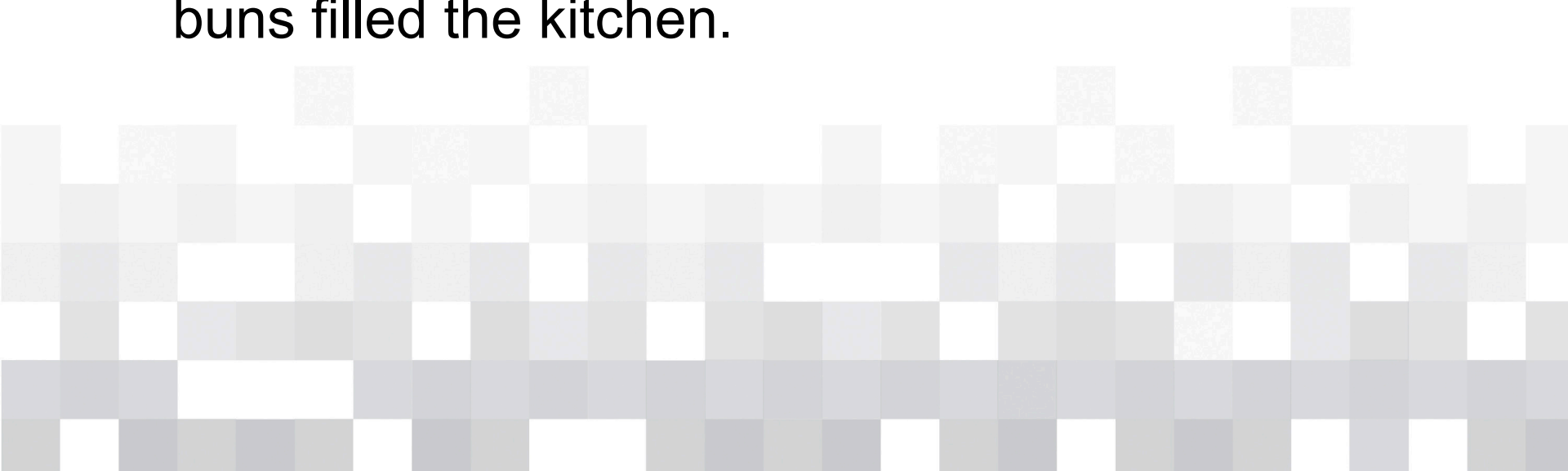
The listing comma



The comma could be replaced by 'and'.

This is a provocative **and** disturbing book.

The sweet **and** scintillating aroma of cinnamon buns filled the kitchen.



The listing comma



Or you could change the order of adjectives without affecting the meaning.

This is a provocative, disturbing book.

This is a disturbing, provocative book.

The sweet, scintillating aroma of cinnamon buns filled the kitchen.

The scintillating, sweet aroma of cinnamon buns filled the kitchen.

The listing comma



Do not use a comma if the adjectives do not describe the same noun to an equal degree (cumulative adjectives).

She likes red wines.

She likes Australian red wines.

She likes dry Australian red wines.

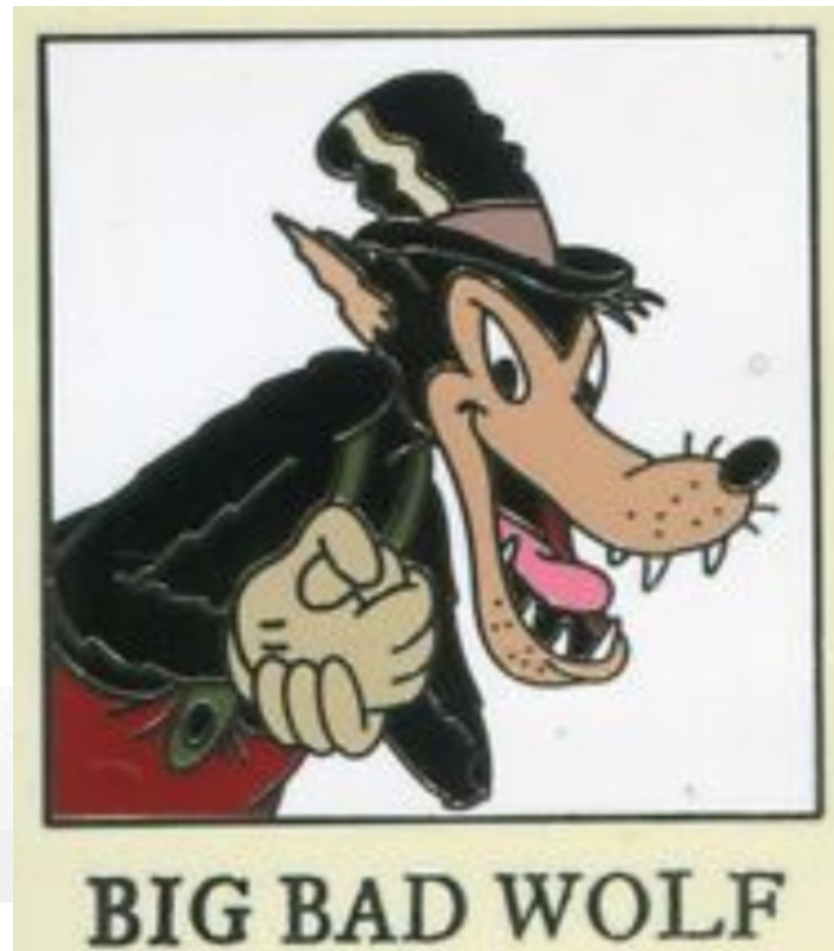


Cumulative adjectives are listed in order



- | | |
|-------------|-------------|
| 1. Opinion | a lovely |
| 2. Size | little |
| 3. Age | old |
| 4. Shape | rectangular |
| 5. Colour | green |
| 6. Origin | French |
| 7. Material | silver |
| 8. Purpose | whittling |
| 9. Noun | knife. |

There are exceptions...



Note from a copy editor



"The convention of placing a comma between coordinate adjectives seems to be fading, perhaps as part of the trend toward open punctuation, perhaps because the absence of this comma rarely confuses readers, or perhaps because the distinction between coordinate and non-coordinate adjectives is sometimes hard to apply."

Listing comma rules



1. Use a listing comma in a list wherever you could conceivably use the word and (or or) instead.
2. Do not use a listing comma anywhere else.
3. Put a listing comma before 'and' or 'or' only if this is necessary to make your meaning clear.

The joining comma



- Used to join two complete sentences into a single sentence.
- Must be followed by a suitable connecting word (and, or, but, yet and while).



(Dated) Examples



- Norway has applied to join the EC, and Sweden is expected to do the same.
- You must hand in your essay by Friday, or you will receive a mark of zero.
- Britain has long been isolated in Europe, but now she is beginning to find allies.
- Billions of dollars have been hurled into the Star Wars projects, yet we appear to have nothing to show for this colossal expenditure.
- A dropped goal counts three points in rugby union, while in rugby league it only counts one point.

Joining commas



If the two independent clauses are very short, you can omit the comma. The trend nowadays is to omit the comma wherever possible.

Examples:

I cooked and she cleaned.

Lisa made cookies and Pedro baked a cake.

Raise your right hand and repeat after me.

Joining commas



If the conjunction is only joining parts of the independent clauses (i.e., the second subject and/or verb is dropped because it is the same), no comma should be used.

For example:

- We finished the report and presented it to the boss.
- I'll call him tonight or email him tomorrow.

Joining commas



The exceptions are if using a comma prevents confusion.

Confusing: I saw that she was busy and prepared to leave.

Clearer with comma: I saw that she was busy, and prepared to leave.

The joining comma



Which sentences are correct?

1. Grammar is boring but necessary.
2. Grammar is boring, but necessary.
3. Grammar is boring but it's necessary.
4. Grammar is boring, but it's necessary.

The joining comma



Which sentences are correct?

1. Grammar is boring but necessary. CORRECT
2. Grammar is boring, but necessary. INCORRECT
3. Grammar is boring but it's necessary. INCORRECT
4. Grammar is boring, but it's necessary. CORRECT

Comma splices



- You cannot join two independent clauses with a comma alone
- You need a conjunction or a semicolon.



Comma splices



INCORRECT

The British are notoriously bad at learning foreign languages, the Dutch are famously good at it.

CORRECT

The British are notoriously bad at learning foreign languages, but the Dutch are famously good at it.

The British are notoriously bad at learning foreign languages; the Dutch are famously good at it.

Joining commas



- Joining commas are used with: and, or, but, yet and while.
- Most other connecting words cannot be preceded by a joining comma (e.g. however, therefore, hence, consequently, nevertheless and thus)

Joining commas



INCORRECT

- Saturn was long thought to be the only ringed planet, however, this is now known not to be the case.
- Two members of the expedition were too ill to continue, nevertheless, the others decided to press on.
- Liverpool are five points behind the leaders, therefore, they must win both their remaining games.

Joining commas



CORRECT

- Saturn was long thought to be the only ringed planet. **However**, this is now known not to be the case.
- Two members of the expedition were too ill to continue. **Nevertheless**, the others decided to press on.
- Liverpool are five points behind the leaders. **Therefore**, they must win both their remaining games.

Note:



If you introduce a sentence with a transition word (e.g. however, hence, indeed, furthermore), follow it with a comma.

- However the model is not always accurate.
INCORRECT
- However, the model is not always accurate.
CORRECT

Joining comma rules



1. Use a joining comma to join two complete sentences with one of the words and, or, but, yet or while.
2. Do not use a joining comma in any other way.



The gapping comma



Used to show that one or more words have been left out when the missing words would simply repeat the words already used earlier in the same sentence.



The gapping comma



Example:

Some Norwegians wanted to base their national language on the speech of the capital city; others **wanted to base it** on the speech of the rural countryside.

Some Norwegians wanted to base their national language on the speech of the capital city; others, on the speech of the rural countryside.

The gapping comma



Example:

Italy is famous for her composers and musicians,
France **for her** chefs and philosophers, and Poland **for**
her mathematicians and logicians.

Italy is famous for her composers and musicians,
France, **for her** chefs and philosophers, and Poland,
for her mathematicians and logicians.

Note:



It is not always necessary to use gapping commas if the meaning is clear without them, so use your discretion.

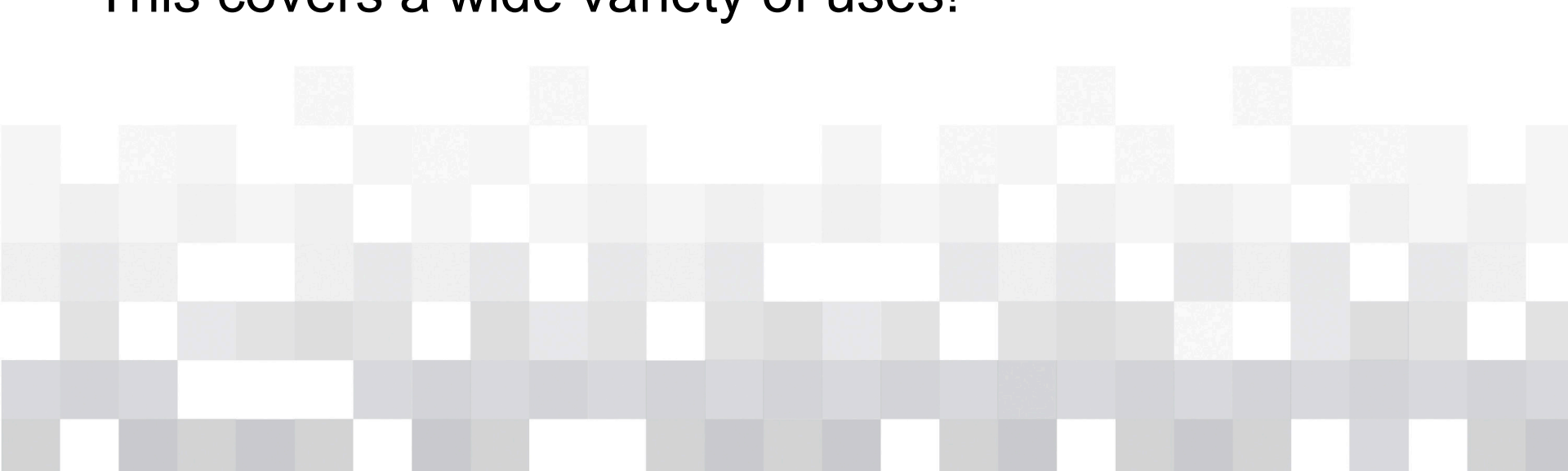


Bracketing commas



According to Trask, bracketing commas are used to mark off a weak interruption of the sentence — that is, an interruption which does not disturb the smooth flow of the sentence.

This covers a wide variety of uses!



Bracketing commas



In a long sentence, you can use commas to separate out extra information and make the sentence easier to read. These commas do the same job as brackets but look a lot neater in your writing.

- LSE (the London School of Economics and Political Science) is in London.
- LSE, the London School of Economics and Political Science, is in London.

Alternative punctuation.



- While on holiday in London, Simon Schmidt, a fireman from New York, rescued a cat from a tree.
(commas)
- While on holiday in London, Simon Schmidt (a fireman from New York) rescued a cat from a tree.
(brackets)
- While on holiday in London, Simon Schmidt – a fireman from New York – rescued a cat from a tree.
(dashes)

Choose punctuation that assists the reader



Compare:

Last night, Josie, an escaped wallaby from London Zoo, attacked two young sisters, Rebecca and Rose Evans, in a bid to steal their crisps.

Last night, Josie (an escaped wallaby from London Zoo) attacked two young sisters – Rebecca and Rose Evans – in a bid to steal their crisps.

Bracketing commas



Commas are used in ‘non-defining’ relative clauses (where the information in the relative clause is not essential).

They are not used in ‘defining’ relative clauses (where the information in the clause is essential).



What's the difference?



- A. The meeting which was attended by all the shareholders came to a unanimous decision.
- B. The meeting, which was attended by all the shareholders, came to a unanimous decision.



What's the difference?



- A. People who commit heinous crimes will be prosecuted.
- B. People, who commit heinous crimes, will be prosecuted.



What's the difference?



- A. My brother who is a teacher lives in London.
- B. My brother, who is a teacher, lives in London.



What's the difference?



- A. Kangaroos, which only live in Australia, are not endangered.
- B. Kangaroos which only live in Australia are not endangered.



What's the difference?



- A. Students who work hard usually succeed.
- B. Students, who work hard, usually succeed.



Add commas to these sentences



1. These findings we would suggest cast doubt upon his hypothesis.
2. Schliemann of course did his digging before modern archaeology was invented.
3. Yet outside that door lay a whole new world.
4. Darwin's Origin of Species published in 1859 revolutionized biological thinking.
5. Rupert Brooke who was killed in the war at the age of 28 was one of our finest poets.
6. We have been forced to conclude after careful study of the data that the proposed correlations, in spite of their obvious appeal, do not stand up.
7. She groped for her cigarettes and finding them hastily lit one.

Add commas to these sentences



1. These findings, we would suggest, cast doubt upon his hypothesis.
2. Schliemann, of course, did his digging before modern archaeology was invented.
3. Yet outside that door lay a whole new world.
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7. She groped for her cigarettes and finding them hastily lit one.

Bracketing commas (not in a pair)



According to Trask:

“Sometimes a weak interruption comes at the beginning or at the end of its sentence. In such a case, one of the two bracketing commas would logically fall at the beginning or the end of the sentence — but we **never** write a comma at the beginning or at the end of a sentence. As a result, only one of the two bracketing commas is written in this case”.

Introductory phrases



When an adverbial phrase begins a sentence, it's often followed by a comma.

1. Having worked for years in Italy, Susan speaks excellent Italian.
2. Unlike most nations, Britain has no written constitution.
3. Although Mercury is closer to the sun, Venus has the higher surface temperature.
4. After capturing the Aztec capital, Cortés turned his attention to the Pacific.

Concluding phrases



1. The use of dictionaries is not allowed, which strikes me as preposterous.
2. The pronunciation of English is changing rapidly, we are told.
3. The Rose Parade is held in Pasadena, a suburb of Los Angeles.

Note:



If a dependent clause comes before the independent clause, use a comma.

- Even though it was raining, I didn't bring an umbrella.
- Because you reminded him, he brought the necessary documents to the meeting.
- If she calls in sick, I will take over for her.

If the dependent clause comes after the independent clause, don't use a comma.

- I didn't bring an umbrella even though it was raining.
- He brought the necessary documents to the meeting because you reminded him.
- I will take over for her if she calls in sick.

What's the difference?



Most of the time,
travellers worry
about their luggage.



Most of the time
travellers worry
about their luggage.



What's the difference?



Stop clubbing baby seals.



Stop clubbing, baby seals.



What's the difference?



Let's eat Grandma.



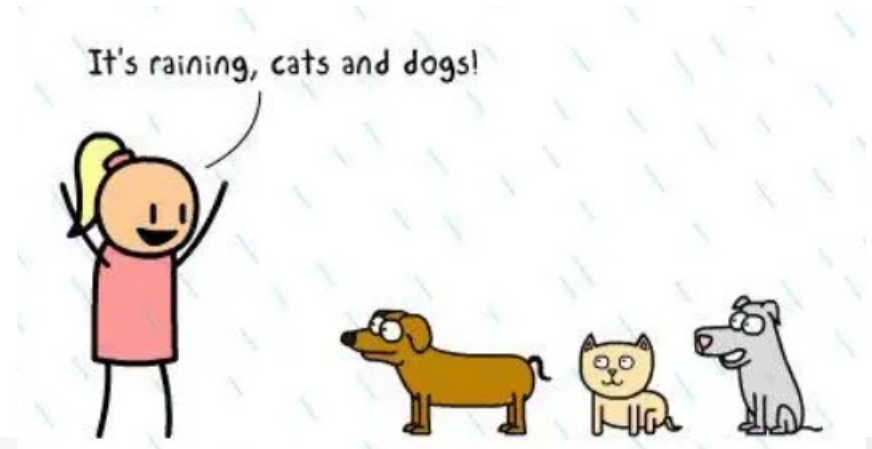
Let's eat, Grandma.



What's the difference?

It's raining cats and dogs.

It's raining, cats and dogs.



HELP A THIEF!!



YAY!!



WHY AREN'T YOU
ARRESTING HIM??



COMMAS, LADY!!



“A woman, without her man, is nothing.”

“A woman: without her, man is nothing.”

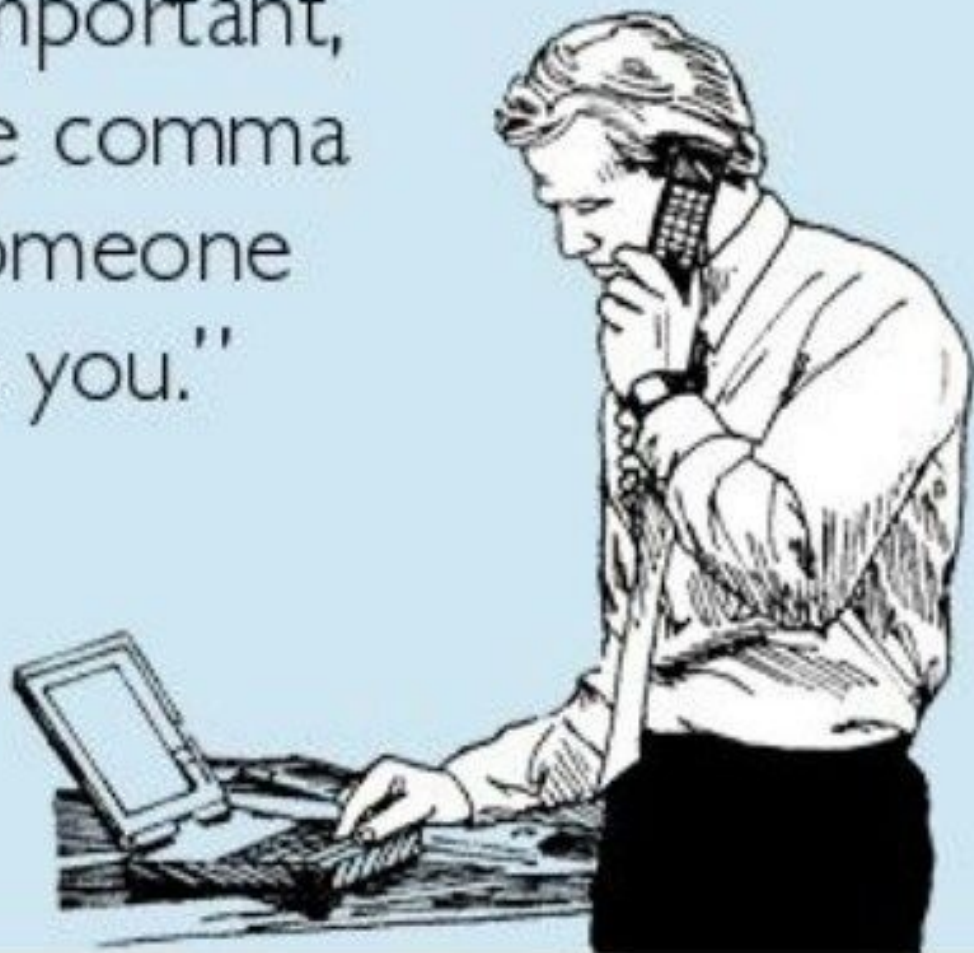
Punctuation is powerful.



Grammarly Cards

If you don't think
punctuation is important,
try forgetting the comma
when you tell someone
"I'm sorry, I love you."

som^{ee}cards
user card



Written by Jamie Capria

I'M NOT RIGHT IN THE HEAD.COM

If you don't think punctuation is important, try leaving out the semicolon when you tell someone, "I'm sorry; I love you."

